great, voice-y opening

You come in come in, I say. He comes in, quiet, courteous, eyes invasively bright. His gaze darts around the cylindrical volume of my studio and his neck cranes, following the fifty feet windows up. This is my abode, a studio no more than twenty paces across but high and deep, it is a well of books and glass. On the shelves are books, leaflets. Notes sprinkled between yellow pages jutted out and when the universe deemed it serendipitous, I'll find one that spoke to my moment of need. One such note read something like: Show them what you want to show them; make them weep, make them cry, and at the end love them some; Finally tell them what you've just told them and say goodbye. I slide it back into its niche with a my index finger. He watches.

good

Mr. Bruce, I ask, what is your last name?

It is just Bruce, he says. If he had an bionic eye, he would have scanned my residence, taking an index of all my belongings to encapsulate me. But I think he does not. He has very biological eyes, very human eyes, eyes that were pink and capillary crawled because they are dry, and when he blinks they are a little wet. He blinks infrequently. His eyelids are closed a smidge long before they are softly opened. I bat my eyes against the oblique sunlight - they too are dry.

Bruce, do you really think you can replicate me? I fold my arms and watch as he traces his fingers along the book spines. He lingers on the old books whose bindings produce a protrusion like ~~a~~ vertebrae. Then he moves on. It was early morning and I had set the curtains and glass opacity to let in a mystic, luminous light. Outside on the water it is clear, a rare day when the fog does not visit. I see the waves break against the crags beneath my windows. Lichen. Moss. Gebraun knee deep in the salt water scrapping oxidized rust from the house's bronze stilts.

yes!

is this a person?

If this is the first time they are introduced, make it clearer e.g. "My robot assistant Gebraun…."

I don't seek to replicate you Mr. Denari, my job is to replace you, Bruce says. My attention returns to the room.

this feels a little bit like a rough segue. If his physical sensations are immediate, there's no time for this. Order of operations

The impact to my ego is immediate. A flurry of spiked sensations shorten my breath. I hold and slow its the release. Easing, I reclaim my unlined mask. Despire my incredulity, the matter-of-factness of his tone seduces me to curiosity. I'm also a gambling man.

unclear if this means his face or an external mask

I doubt very highly you can replace me, I add with a dipped pause, but it will be amusing to see you try.

May I? He asks, motioning the slide ladder.

Of course whatever you need, tell me Bruce, do you… how do you work? Are you sleuthing?

He steps onto the ladder step with a heavy heel and the penumatics hiss and the suspension bobbles before settling. Once the ladder had leveled, he pulls along the bookshelf using the columns of the shelves as anchor. That annoys me. I had installed white, hooked pegs at regularly length along the shelves to act as anchors. The thought of his hands smearing grease on the lacquer gives my stomach a squeeze. But I leave it alone. As much as he is learning from me, I learn from him. It was rare to see a Vulture at work and the members of the Symposium had said that he was the best.

good!

So far I'm unimpressed. He looks down to me from twenty feet up as if he had caught my thought.

How do you organize your books Maestro? He asks.

semicolon or em-dash

What do you suppose Bruce? I say. It is as amusing to watch him, it is like watching a mouse in an open maze. I see all the corridors, deadends, I see where the cheese is hidden ~~from my vantage~~. I decide to game with him a bit.

I can't give everything away to you, especially as the one being replaced out, I say.

I'd cut this. At first it reads like you are trying to summarize something else; without it, it's clearer he's muttering titles

He mumbles, talking to himself and speaking out loud to reason with my question: Themes are scattered, no clear taxonomy. Books on the biology and horticulture next to histories of wars. No authors' names clustered with his own nor neighbored with others who wrote about the same. Neither by nationality, timeline, geography, personality, philosophy.

reword- "his" reads like "Bruce's" / then like all authors are male

He continues. Between novellas there are poems, amongst poems there are adages, notes, tunes, stanzas mixed with sheet music with photographs of architecture. And, enshrouding these humanist and aesthetic studies are databooks on physics as well as applied mathematics and blueprints of machinery. He looks to me, I can't make much sense of it, he says.

all right

It is alright, I say tempering my voice to not sound self-satisfactory. You've just gotten here Mr. Bruce - Bruce - maybe you'll make some inroads. Or, maybe, you'll run out of time before your contract.

Maestro Marco, you have much to gain too when I succeed, he says as he untucks a hefty volume. I reconigze it by the emblem on its spine as an old incomplete epic called *The Lyoness*.

good

It was my last work from my immature period. Before I amazed the world with *The Stellar Rose*; and the name *Marco di Francesco d'Assisi da Presidio* became a known name.

I want to tell him to be careful with that folio but the replacement contract from the Symposium states that, within reason, I could not interfere with the Vulture's work. I spat at that requirement. I say to him, respectfully now Bruce, those are brittle pages.

respectfully: Now

He returns a courteous nod in acknowledgement.

Thirty percent is an insult, I reply.

That is, he says - Of all works in perpetuity, created in multi-parallel, day and night, without rest, on this and future worlds, for each client and for each demographic, for the rest of

your life and for two subsequent generations if you have children. He pauses. That's a lot of equity and a lot of wealth, he says.

But to stop me from creation? To stop my spirit and what gives my life vigor? Do you know what it's been to slave for decades, to take risks, to be diminished to a shade when your untalentless peers rise to high places, all on this singular bet that I, *Marco di Francesco d'Assisi*, will succeed? I say to him.

h

Would you do it again? He asks.

Yes, I say, without the need of a thought. I have known no other life and cannot imagine one more worthwhile.

He lowers the ladder.

What if you were not discovered by the Symposium and your work did not become a success with the public? You know how fickle and tempetuous life is for new art, he says.

maybe reword?
"Life" is so broad

I seize. To be a pauper, to have undergone all that toil and humiliation only to live in a LifeCube on government micro-bips, resenting everyone and scorning everything, because I feel the world owed me something for my intention. This thought tapped into a dessicated version of myself living in squalor. I shudder at my fortune. No, Bruce, I say, I would not do it again if it were that. I sigh.

good. However, I can't tell from the tense/wording if this was his past, or an imagined future

1x for a version of "step
1 adverb

He has descended the ladder now, stepping gingerly off the step noiselessly onto the wooden flooring. I didn't mean to upset you, he says and his tone was even and sympathetic. I wave his apology away with a flick of my wrist, dimissing the effect his question had on my mood. I face the window and breathe deeply. It was noon and the Sun crossed his arms staring down.

is

has

you've slipped out of present tense. I thought present tense was working well

so the past poverty was real?

It is alright, I say turning back, some of those years are hard to relive and I thank God every day for what he's done.

Bruce seats cross-legged in the brown leather armchair that Gebraun had fetched for guests. I slump into my own.

Water? I ask.

He agrees. I motion for Gebraun to bring water.

Why do you do this? I ask. You must have enough money by now. I saw you replaced (what an ugly word) what's his name, that bodysculpter.

great name Brill Walls, he answered.

Yes, Walls, I say and relax into my thinking pose with my chin on my fist. He did marvelous work, I say, but unsightly to think about. Bruce nods. What was the hardest part about replacing him? I ask.

good I can't talk about other candidates, he says.

Candidates, I let that word linger, dragging out the vowels.

Can-Di-Dates To-Be Re-Pla-Ced. What a fate it is to be erased and defaced by you monkey mechanics whilst He made us in His image, I say musically. Why? The Board won't let you? I ask.

Yes, all techniques are proprietary knowledge of the Board.

good Has a vulture ever been replaced?

kind of a lot. pick 1, maybe 2 max

I see a lecherous grin widen across his face unzipping open to oyster flat teeth. In the crease between teeth I see the space between tombstones. He does not say. He smiles. That was enough. Savage, I say.

nibble?

I lower my neck and nib on my thumb. I harden my gaze and take him in. For minutes I'm like this, synthesizing, putting together, analyzing, taking him apart. The freshly crewed hair slicked back, the ears with felt hairs, the lean musculature that is exposed through his thin shirt only as hints of dense bone.

kind of hard to see. Felt like "Kermit"?

how can musculature be bone?
Do your "Diane von Furstenburg and take 1 piece of jewelry off

I'm real, he says.

Gebraun enters and sets down two thin glasses of glass. I motion Gebraun to us.

him

Do you think Gebraun is real? I ask Bruce.

He looks at the mute sunburnt man who is well-preserved. I look at Gebraun, high check bones, skin darkened with a subdermal tan, bleached bristly hair that contrast against his skin, blue-green eyes, nails perfectly cut, cuticals perfectly trimmed.

scale back; too many descriptors

Bruce takes the same thinking posture as me, the same tics. Is he mimicking me? He chews on his index fingers as he mulls over Gebraun.

Gebraun, Bruce asks, are you real? I scoff. This ruins the game.

I am not, sir, Gebraun answers.

What is your serial? Bruce asks.

Romeo loves Juliet only because he loves what is amiss in himself, sir, Gebraun says.

I purse my lips. What a sully way to ruin the game. I wave Gebraun away. I would not play you in cards Bruce, I say.

good

You're disappointed, he says.

I thought you Vultures would be more observant and more respectable, I say.

You've assumed my answer, Bruce says.

I look at him. I really look at him.

move down to next para

Gebraun is real, Bruce says, but he doesn't know. My heart races.

Bruce continues: It is against New Ethics 9.0.2 to delude an automaton to be real, and corollary states it is illegal to subvert a human's memory via brain-wipe to convince his living consciousness as anything other than his biological identity and history. This is expanded in New Ethics Rights of Human Consciousness 1.0.x. Under the law *Let man think, let man be.* The sentence for violation is maximum life in prison, or in the most severe cases, brain-wipe and forced labor in the arctic energy colonies.

Bravo! I say. I sit on the edge of my seat now gripping my armrest. What else? I press him.

His serial truth statement checks that he is a legal unit, so someone in the Symmposium must have called on a special favor. This is not unheard of… more goes on in the upper echelon than most would think. But even they would not risk going against New Ethics. To have this unit allowed in the open, most likely it was medical. There's no scarf line to suggest a face replacement, even Walls could make those invisible. Gebraun likely was a friend of yours, but not a lover. Your pheromone response shows admiration, not attraction. You were in the war, Maestro? A war buddy, suffered from nerve agents, brain death at home. Those are common for veterans.

He was a fellow prisoner of war, I say. I laugh to myself. So many details correct and I cannot stop from smiling. I have not been this entertained in a long while.

Bruce nods, He rises and extends his arm. I rise and we shake.

Thanks for letting me into your house, Maestro, he says, never been to war myself but I hear all artists are envious of the ones made from wars.

It makes for good material, I say.

B

Bruce heads for the front, but before he is out, he looks at me and says, by the way Maestro, your secret is safe with me.

I raise my brow. Gebraun?

The Symposium does not need to know you are illiterate, he says, it seems unimportant to how you work.

says, It

He tips his head. I nod to his exit. The door is shut. I hear the hum of the drone outside and see it rise with Bruce pointing to the city. Once it had cleared the privacy envelope, the thrusters fire. All I hear is a small drop like a stone in a pond. Then the vehicle sped into dusk.

clears

speeds

So tell me Mr. Bruce, how did you discover my little secret? I say.

He is seated once again in that chair and I in mine as the sun goes to rest and mistress moon rises on another night. I blow out some smoke deeply taken into my lungs, the tendrils waft in the air, the smoke's delicate wisps catch on blades of light. It all rises twisting to the cyclone filter in the roof. I glance at the butler's overwatch on the mantle of my bookshelf disguised as an ancient mariner's bust, his eyes winced, his face distraught.

IDK what this is

good

Was it that the books had gathered dust? I ask.

He shakes his head.

So what is it then? I say, growing a bit wary of goading.

Your books are dry, he says.

I look at them on the shelf and I see no difference.

When books are left on display, their pages will warp from the change in moisture as the room cycles through condensation and evaporation. The paper curls like a fern leaf; Many of your books have these crinkled pages, he says.

m

Itt's an old house with old climate control, so what, I say.

And they're not battered, Bruce says.

Battered? I say.

For an artist as consumed by work as you, I had expected the books to be abused; worn; embattled. There are none like that. When one really attacks a book, it is a carnal activity, the spine is split, the ribs spread to reveal the innards, the glue holding the binding cracks. But the spines of your books have no crease. If they have been read, they've been read delicately, the pages only peeked at.

We all have different ways to read don't we, I say, unsure why I was putting on a rouse.

ruse

They're vertical, like a library for storage, he says.

I glance at the books, organized into cells like plant walls containing these dead pages made from bygone cellulose. good

Perhaps it's a quirk, Bruce says, but many writers whom I've replaced leave their frequented books in stacks. Mostly it is an easy habit; sometimes the titles are easier to read horizontal.

Replaced many writers have you? I ask.

Many, Bruce says and if I've caught the light correct in his eye, he says it without pride.

These deductions are entertaining, I say, but it seems you are leaping to conclusions. I cross my legs and swivel in my chair, examining him but see nothing more than a husk in a suit

what is shining - the husk or the suit?

shining silver from the moonlight. His silhouette is meticulously done. As meticulous as me. No, he cannot be, none have made the same vows as I.

good

I sensed something didn't fit, he says, so I tested it by switching your books.

I laugh at his answer. I look at the shelves - I see colors, shapes, textures, symbols - I see totems to humanity to be venerated and an amalgam that withheld its meaning from me. And

two big words too close together. Or maybe it that's there's nothing concrete after "amalgam". But the back part sentence is all concepts and no imagery to "hang your hat on"

then you bluffed? I say to him.

You didn't deny my claim, he says.

I chuckle. I had assumed he knew more than he did; the claim had caught me by surprise. To anyone of lesser reputation with less mystique, I may have exploded. How would anyone dare accuse the Merlin of the Gestalt (as the publications put it) of being an illiterate. I laugh.

He opens his jacket, reaching in, and reveals a folder.

Without thinking, eyes glaring like a demon, I lunge forward and snatch it from him. Give me that! I scream.

rifle

He relinquishes my folio and holds his hands open. I riffle through it, pages after pages of

good

bibliphilia, lines and loop. I look a the symbols but that part of my brain remains dense and dead.

How dare you, I snap.

Once under replacement, ownership of all property belonging to the candidate is transferred to his employer, The Symposium, and the Board, he says, but I will ask next time.

I want you to get out! I grit through my teeth.

This is technically my house, Bruce says.

Out!

He stands, pats down his slacks and straightens his jacket. I know you're stuck, he says, and I can help you finish the work. Without waiting for a reply, he leaves through the door.

I don't think this is the word you want?

Still clutching the folio, I swivel to face the window in time to see his transport exude through the privacy envelope. The impact of the thrusters ripples the field. Then he is gone.

how to make this second aero-departure a little different than in the previous scene? Maybe end on Marco's interiority this time?